

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Being Kind to Myself

In December, the class did the Friend Test for the first time. The Friend Test is one of the most important tools the kids of Room 12 will learn this year. It will follow them, in different forms, all the way through Book Five, when they are seventeen and eighteen and about to leave home, and they will still be doing it then.

Here is the Friend Test:

If your best friend said about themselves the same thing you are saying about yourself right now — would you say what you are saying to them? Or would you say something different?

Ms. Calloway introduced it on a Wednesday morning. She put Sammy on her hand and Sammy held up a small dry-erase board with two lines on it.

THE FRIEND TEST

What I say to MYSELF: ____ What I would say to my BEST FRIEND in the same situation: ____ "Friends," said Sammy. "Most of you talk to yourselves all day long. Inside your own head. And most of you are MEAN to yourselves in a way you would NEVER be mean to a friend. You do not even notice you are doing it, because it has been going on for so long that the unkind voice just sounds like thinking. But it is not thinking. It is Grumpy Gus, and Grumpy Gus has been quietly running the show."

The kids leaned in. They had heard about Grumpy Gus in October. They had not put it together with the inside voice yet.

"Today," said Sammy, "we are going to do an experiment. I am going to give you a piece of paper. On the left side, I want you to write something unkind that you have said to yourself recently. Something inside-your-head unkind. Like I am stupid. Or I am bad at this. Or Nobody likes me. Or whatever Grumpy Gus has been saying."

The kids took their papers.

"Then," said Sammy, "on the right side, I want you to imagine that your best friend just said that thing about THEMSELVES. And I want you to write what YOU would say to YOUR best friend in that moment. The exact words."

Priya, who is a careful child, started writing immediately.

In the left column, Priya wrote: I am bad at spelling.

In the right column, Priya thought for a long time. Then she wrote, slowly: You got most of them right. You are still learning. Three wrong is not bad at all. Spelling takes practice.

Priya stared at her paper.

She had never, ever, in her whole six and a half years, said anything like the right-column sentence to herself. She had said it to other kids — many times. She had said it to her little brother. She had said it to her cousin. She had even said it, once, to a girl in kindergarten who had been crying because she could not spell her own last name.

But she had never said it to herself.

Priya put her hand up.

"Yes, Priya?"

"Why don't I talk to myself the way I talk to my friends?"

The room got quiet.

Ms. Calloway came over and sat down on the carpet next to Priya. "That, Priya," she said, "is one of the most important questions in this whole book — I mean, in this whole year. Most adults do not even know to ask it. You just asked it when you are six years old. Wow."

Priya did not smile, exactly. But she sat up a little.

"I do not know the full answer," said Ms. Calloway. "Nobody knows the full answer. Some of it is that we forget that we are also a person. We treat ourselves like we are not on the team. We treat our friends like they ARE on the team."

"What we are going to practice in this room, all year, is putting yourself BACK on the team. You are on your team. You have been on your team this whole time. You forgot. We are going to remember together." Priya thought about that.

"Okay," she said.

Then she did something interesting. She picked up her paper, very carefully, and she crossed out the left column — the I am bad at spelling line.

In its place, she wrote: I am still learning. Three wrong is not bad at all. Spelling takes practice.

She read it twice.

"Better," she said, to no one in particular.

Then she put the paper in her journal.

Sofia did the Friend Test next to her, and her left column said I am clumsy and I make people cry. (She was still thinking about the apples.) Her right column said You apologized. The kindergartener is fine. Accidents happen.

Sofia read her right column three times.

Maya did the Friend Test, and her left column said Nobody really wants me here. Her right column took her a long time to write. But she wrote, eventually: Everybody in your class

knows your name. Sammy already knows you are here. You belong here.

Ms. Calloway walked the room slowly, reading over shoulders. She did not say anything. She just put her hand, very lightly, on the top of each child's head as she passed.

Some of the things she read that day she would carry with her for the rest of her teaching career.

Maya's right column was one of them.